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送信者: Ian Bremmer 受信日時: 2026-08-03 20:52

【メール原文】

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iran

the ceasefire ended when the us and iran clashed over competing interpretations of the memorandum of understanding. the americans pushed for a full opening of the strait of hormuz; the iranians shot at transiting ships to ensure they had control of the waterway...or nobody could use it. leading the americans to restart military strikes and enforce a blockade.

after nearly two weeks of that, the americans tried for compromise again. unilaterally ending strikes and offering a restart of backchannel negotiations with the iranians. that moved ahead for a while, with the omanis floating the prospect of an agreement that would share control (and administrative fees) of the strait between the two countries. iran rejected the offer and restarted military strikes despite the americans having discontinued them—with missile strikes against a us base in jordan and drone strikes against two us-owned ships in an egyptian port (while iran hasn't restarted strikes against shipping in the hormuz because the traffic largely ended with the ceasefire failure and the us blockade). there were also a number of iranian proxy strikes from shia militias in iraq against energy facilities in saudi arabia, from the houthis in yemen against saudi tankers, and also from hezbollah against israeli defense force fighters operating in the south of lebanon. with the americans responding with force (albeit performatively, according to white house sources) against military targets in iran.

president trump is continuing to make serious threats against the iranians, asking the pentagon for options including taking out another leadership group (in the hopes that a new group of leaders would be more willing to compromise), launching strikes against iran's nuclear facilities, and expanding us strikes on infrastructure targets. but he remains reluctant to order any dramatic escalation given the expected iranian retaliation (despite president trump repeatedly publicly downplaying iran's military capabilities), instead expressing frustration to his advisors that they haven't yet gotten an acceptable deal out of the iranians. meanwhile, islamic republic leadership maintains the view that they should take a consistent hard line to show that they'll tolerate further damage and exact more costs (on the strait and on the gulf states) than the americans are prepared to tolerate (all the while pushing oil prices up).

the biggest problem is iran's still-functioning military capabilities. us military projections are that iran retains more than enough missiles and drones to stay in the fight for the foreseeable future. with thousands of short-range ballistic missiles and mobile launchers (well over 50% of iran's pre-war inventories) remaining intact. the united states and coalition allies can intercept over 90% of iran's total missile and drone strikes (not bad given that iran generally fires at least three decoys for each shahed drone), but those getting through can cause significant damage—and the iranians have already damaged or destroyed all sorts of us military sites: from hangars, barracks and fuel depots to aircraft, radar, communications and air defense equipment. also importantly, iran's attacks have been precise,

with virtually no craters in military base strikes, meaning that they know where high-value assets are positioned in real time and, accordingly, clearly have been benefiting from (russian) satellite support.

i'm not expecting much to change in the coming weeks. the americans are likely to escalate as president trump gets more frustrated, but continued military restraint is as notable as the decision to restart the blockade of the strait—the americans are unwilling to risk dramatic escalation. that message resonates loud and clear with the islamic republic (as do leaked us military statements about the limited stocks of us munitions remaining in the region), giving iran's leadership no reason to back away from their maximalist demands at the negotiating table.

ukraine

a more stable relationship has been emerging between the united states and ukraine. president volodymyr zelensky has more to offer the americans (in terms of his country's rapidly expanding drone capabilities and military experience); that, combined with the united states's lack of progress with russian president vladimir putin, makes president trump more willing to lean into the ukraine relationship...and made for a particularly friendly visit by zelensky at the white house last week.

it's a testament to trump's recency bias and transactionalism. yes, trump saw opportunities to make a lot of money out of restarting a constructive relationship with the kremlin. and yes, trump was personally angry with the ukrainian president for refusing to open an investigation into then vice president joe biden and his son hunter. but that was then. now, ukraine has more cards...and so president trump is prepared to let bygones be bygones. the united states has stepped up its provision of real-time intelligence to ukraine, allowing them to develop more sophisticated targeting plans for energy and related sites deep inside russia. the biden administration had a rigid process for sharing intelligence because it was worried about prompting a dangerous spiral of escalation, now president trump is essentially telling the ukrainians to let the russians have it.

but the trump pivot on ukraine only goes so far. at the nato summit in ankara, trump decided to allow licensing of patriot missiles, which would have a major eventual impact on ukraine's ability to defend itself against long-range russian missiles—the principal way russia is presently causing damage to ukraine's civilians and economy. but last week, on the back of zelensky's trip, trump said he hadn't yet decided to proceed given the risks of doing so. further, during his trip, zelensky tried to push the argument that russia is providing support for iran, but trump isn't prepared to take further action on the back of that argument.

i should note that i'm skeptical of a meaningful "iran-ukraine war alignment" despite coverage of growing linkage of the two wars—with the ukrainians hitting an iranian vessel in the caspian sea and the iranians threatening a hostile response. ukraine is trying to stop vessels thought to be carrying military supplies from using russian ports, not as destabilizing as the iranians are disrupting ship traffic not respecting iranian control of the strait of hormuz. that doesn't imply either a widening of the war or an interest in doing so.

meanwhile, it's becoming increasingly apparent that putin is in a fraught, no-win situation. kazakhstan president kassym-jomart tokayev, one of putin's closest strategic partners, made a direct statement in favor of the war ending while meeting with the russian president a week ago—he was politely but firmly rebuffed. so too with xi jinping's recent meeting with putin, after private suggestions that the war is becoming increasingly costly and that the russians would be better off accepting a ceasefire. again, with zero interest from putin. absent any potential for the war settling down, putin is escalating—launching more indiscriminate missile strikes against civilian targets across the ukrainian capital kyiv, as well as

repeated strikes on ukraine's primary port facilities to limit ukraine's export capacity. going forward, that escalation—putin finding levers to expand the war—is set to increase.

us – china

one of the most consistent trump foreign policies over the last year has been stabilizing the relationship with china. once he realized the costs of economic warfare, he pivoted sharply to derisking. finding ways to work together more constructively in trade and investment (hence the trade and investment boards presently being negotiated), engaging in more frequent and high-level military-to-military connection, and offering more solicitous diplomacy around china's key security issues: lowering the temperature on taiwan and kicking the can on new defense packages, allowing a lapse in the executive order on hong kong that treated the territory restrictively, and scaling back freedom of navigation operations in the south china sea.

but i'm increasingly thinking it's not sustainable and that this more stable path that emerged in 2025 will soon be stress-tested in ways that neither government has seen before. because of quickly advancing chinese capabilities and how quickly ai risks are becoming serious in relation to the national security of both countries. china's decision to lean into inexpensive, open-source models is a different bet on the future of ai than the americans. but it will bring ai at scale less expensively to consumers and industrial users in the west and global south—competition (and data collection) that will prove unwelcome to the us intelligence and defense community. separately, chinese models will bring some of the same cyber, bio, and alignment risks as american frontier models, with little lag in timeframe; but chinese companies won't respond to us government concerns on that front the way anthropic and openai have. which makes it likely the united states will put serious restrictions on the us-china ai relationship in the coming months—from restricting chinese access to us models, limiting us access to chinese open-weight models, and looking to use political leverage to expand (non-chinese) global adoption of american ai.

some of this is already underway: the trump administration has been actively weighing a ban on chinese open-weight models, and the internal us debate is live and contentious, with companies like meta, nvidia and microsoft pushing back hard against restrictions that would, in their view, effectively ban open-source ai altogether. both countries are also starting to mirror each other—beijing has been in talks with alibaba, bytedance, and z.ai about restricting foreign access to their own advanced model weights, a potential reversal of china's open-source strategy.

all of this would represent a key acceleration in the decoupling of advanced technologies between the two countries. which i see running in parallel in other sectors—the united states just last week banned humanoid robots from china (an area where the chinese have a substantial tech and pricing lead over the americans). china's recent advances in lithography are also notable, even if more modest than the headlines suggest. a state-backed shanghai firm has begun production of immersion duv machines capable of 28nm chips, a milestone for domestic self-sufficiency, even if the technology still trails asml by several generations. that's likely to turn the united states away from the nvidia argument that selling them advanced chips is a good idea (for anyone but nvidia). i'm not surprised to see elon musk floating a sale of tesla china right now—his future business model with spacex and xai is necessarily aligned with the united states military-industrial-technological complex, and that's geopolitically incompatible with a large, advanced tech, data-heavy china business.

in short, an ai arms race between the united states and china is becoming a core component of the bilateral relationship. whether or not that is coupled with a useful us-china ai dialogue to limit conflict in

the space—and derisk a future of accelerating, opaque, potentially zero-sum ai conflict—is a key question for the future; agreed us-china ai talks in september, specifically aimed at building governance, will be critical to watch on this front. but nearer term, the question is the extent to which this competition cuts against the recently constructed detente between the two countries. chinese officials have been satisfied with the notion that the trump presidency is more positive for them than they could have imagined...but what happens when facts to the contrary start changing that opinion? will we see beijing shift toward more supply chain restrictions? do broader trade negotiations break down? will we start seeing more great-power hostility on security, on intelligence/espionage?

the high-level politics have managed to limit the economic fallout between the two largest economies over the course of the last year. the ai race will make that much harder to maintain over the coming months.

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a big story from spain, with some 50,000 undocumented migrants from morocco overwhelming spanish border security in their north african enclave of ceuta. most were forced to return in short order, but the live-streaming of a spanish territory suddenly overwhelmed with masses of young men running through the streets is a disaster for the sanchez government, and makes it more likely the next elections (some six months away) will return a conservative government including the far-right vox party, set to gain substantially on the back of the events.

plenty to keep us busy, august notwithstanding. feel free to reach out with any thoughts or questions.

very best,

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